

fearlessly for young men and women, who had a vision for the future. State Chief Election Commissioner J.K. Dutta, who normally summons battalions of central paramilitary forces for poll duty, managed the entire exercise with just unarmed state home guards backed by the local police.

The list of the vanquished is indication enough that the days of the dons may truly be coming to an end. In Siwan, all candidates set up by the notorious RJD MP Mohammed Shahabuddin, now in jail, were defeated. Another dreaded don and LJP MP Surajbhan Singh saw all candidates he backed including his own nephew lose. Relatives of controversial Sunil Pandey, MLA from Piro and one of the patrons of the dreaded Ranvir Sena—a private army of Bhumihar landlords—were rejected. In Fatuah, MLA Saryu Paswan's wife and son were defeated. Said social researcher Dr Shaibal Gupta of the Asian Development Research Institute (ADRI), "All these far-reaching changes were seen because of reservation and people's aversion towards those who have built up their fiefdom in various regions, hijacked development funds and took everything for granted."

The government reserved 50 per cent posts in all categories for women while 20 per cent posts were reserved for OBCs and extremely backwards, 15 per cent for Scheduled Castes and one per cent for Scheduled Tribes in all panchayats and urban bodies. Women contested not just the posts reserved for them but also staked on unreserved posts. And won.

An amazing feature of the election was that for the first time even the candidates from the lower class contested and won. According to Gupta, many young men used this election as an entry point to electoral politics without the blessings of the established political order. Even the massive participa-

tion of voters had surprised State Election Commission and pollsters. Braving the heat wave sweeping the state, over 55 per cent voted, which was higher than the 2002 polls and Assembly polls in 2005. Another element of surprise was that while in 2002 the RJD-backed Yadav candidates had won most of the seats, this time people voted against them with a sense of vengeance.

In fact the changes became visible after last year's panchayat elections. Bihar was the first state to reserve half of all seats and posts for women. Bihar Assembly Speaker Uday Narain

DEMOCRATIC RIGHT: Voters wait for their turn in a booth in Patna

these 1.31 lakh are women. "This is real women-raj at grassroots," the speaker said.

Indeed, it has started happening. Beena Devi, 31, a poor woman who had fought criminals and landlords in Nawadah, is a sort of an icon in the area. Beena, mukhiya of Loharpur, would soon be joining a delegation of 50 women to Lahore organised by the Union Panchayati Raj Ministry. Earlier, due to her performance as mukhiya she was honoured by Lok Sabha Speaker Somnath Chatterjee and UPA chairperson Sonia Gandhi.

This model, Nitish Kumar hopes, would be replicated in future, which in turn would change politics based on



Chaudhary, a well-known champion for Dalit rights, said this well-thought of policy of reservation for women had kicked up changes faster than expected and it would change the colour of politics forever. Now onwards women alone would control grassroots politics and conduct developmental works. "Everywhere in the world, young men and women led revolutions and this has happened in Bihar too," Chaudhary said. Look at the figures: from zila parishad president to pramukh, mukhiya, panchayat samiti, sirpanch and panch there are 2.62 lakh elected representatives and out of

caste, creed, gender and religion.

As the scenario at the grassroots level has started changing, legislators who controlled funds for panchayats and local bodies are in a state of panic. The Comptroller and Auditor General has agreed to Chaudhary's call for auditing of the funds being channelled to panchayats. This again would be first in the country. Now Chaudhary is organising a seminar on 'Control of People's Representatives over Public Fund' with a promise to ensure that its recommendations are followed up by the government.

Much maligned though, Bihar has once again taken the lead in bringing about transparency in governance at the village and town level. It is a development that is bound to have far-reaching impact on politics at the state level. ■



"The voters were so disciplined this time that home guards could manage the elections."

J. K. DUTTA, STATE ELECTION COMMISSIONER, BIHAR